



Saarzya

MENTAL HEALTH & WELLNESS
JOURNAL

ISSUE 01 • WEEKLY EDITION

Understanding Anxiety & The Nervous System

*A practical guide to decoding fear, somatic responses, and finding
grounded balance.*

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"Mental wellness shouldn't feel overwhelming, clinical, or isolating. Saarzya was created to make psychological insights accessible, practical, and deeply human."

EDITORIAL

Co-Founders' Note

Facing the Storm with Understanding

When we first envisioned **Saarzya**, we wanted to strip away the clinical coldness often associated with mental health resources. We wanted to build a bridge between complex psychological research and everyday human experiences.

In this inaugural issue, we address one of the most universal human conditions: anxiety. Anxiety is often treated as an enemy to be defeated or hidden away. However, biologically and psychologically, anxiety is an ancient signaling system — your mind and body's way of asking for protection, attention, or rest.

"Through this edition, our goal is not to eliminate anxiety overnight, but to help you reframe it. When you understand what your nervous system is communicating, you can move from a place of panic to a place of informed self-compassion."

Throughout these pages, you will find accessible breakdowns of autonomic biology, actionable grounding toolkits, and guided journaling prompts. We encourage you to read slowly, reflect deeply, and practice these techniques in your daily routine.

Thank you for being here at the start of our journey. Let's learn and grow together.

— The Co-Founders, Saarzya

PSYCHOLOGY & BIOLOGY

De-coding Anxiety: It's a Signal, Not a Flaw

For many, anxiety feels like a sudden, unprovoked wave. Your heart races, your thoughts spiral into "what-ifs," and your body prepares for a crisis that isn't physically there.

The Physiology of the Threat Response

When your brain perceives stress — whether it is an approaching deadline, a difficult conversation, or an uncertain future — the **amygdala** (the brain's alarm system) sends a distress signal to the **hypothalamus**. This triggers the release of stress hormones, primarily adrenaline and cortisol.

To manage anxiety effectively, we must first understand its evolutionary origin. Anxiety is not a personal failure or a flaw in your character; it is a sophisticated survival mechanism refined over thousands of generations.

Hormonal Actions During Stress

Adrenaline: Increases heart rate, elevates blood pressure, and redirects blood flow to major muscle groups.

Cortisol: Increases glucose in the bloodstream, prioritizing immediate survival functions while temporarily suppressing non-essential systems like digestion and immunity.

In prehistoric times, this physiological cascade saved humans from physical danger. Today, your brain uses that exact same mechanism to respond to emotional, social, and psychological stress. The response isn't broken; it's simply miscalibrated for modern life.

Reframing the Experience

Instead of asking, "Why am I having anxiety?" try shifting the question to: "What is my body trying to protect me from right now?" Recognizing anxiety as a biological protective attempt reduces the secondary shame and frustration that often exacerbates panic.

"Anxiety is a messenger. When we stop fighting the presence of the message, we can finally begin to read its contents."

Cognitive vs. Somatic Anxiety

Anxiety generally manifests in two interconnected domains:

Cognitive Symptoms

Racing thoughts, catastrophic predictions, mental loops, hyper-vigilance, and difficulty concentrating.

Somatic Symptoms

Tight chest, shallow breathing, muscle tension, stomach discomfort, dizziness, and elevated heart rate.

By identifying whether your anxiety is primarily cognitive (mind-driven) or somatic (body-driven) in a given moment, you can select the most effective tool to return to a state of equilibrium.

POLYVAGAL INSIGHTS

Mapping Your Nervous System

Understanding where your body lands during stress allows you to select the right tool to regain balance. Autonomic nervous system responses typically manifest in four distinct states.

THE STRESS SPECTRUM

[Stress Trigger] → Fight / Flight / Freeze / Fawn

1. Fight

Sensations: Clenched jaw, heat in face, tight chest, urge to yell.

Mindset: "I need to control this immediately or defend myself."

2. Flight

Sensations: Fidgeting, shallow breathing, racing heart, restless legs.

Mindset: "I need to escape this situation right now."

3. Freeze

Sensations: Numbness, feeling heavy, brain fog, fatigue.

Mindset: "It is safer if I do not move or make a decision."

4. Fawn

Sensations: Immediate urge to appease, loss of inner boundaries.

Mindset: "If I keep everyone happy, I will be safe."

The Polyvagal Ladder

Dr. Stephen Porges' Polyvagal Theory explains that our nervous system operates like a ladder, moving between three primary evolutionary states:

1. Ventral Vagal State (Safe & Social)

You feel grounded, calm, connected, and curious. Heart rate is steady, and digestion functions normally.

2. Sympathetic State (Mobilized / Fight-Flight)

Activated when danger is sensed. Energy increases, heart rate spikes, and focus narrows to immediate threats.

3. Dorsal Vagal State (Immobilized / Freeze)

Activated when stress feels overwhelming. System shuts down to conserve energy; feelings of hopelessness or disconnection arise.

Recognizing which rung of the ladder you are on is the prerequisite for effective self-regulation. You cannot jump directly from Dorsal Vagal (Freeze) to Ventral Vagal (Calm) without first moving through mild mobilization.

SOMATIC EXERCISES

3 Grounding Techniques for Acute Stress

When your nervous system is dysregulated, logic alone won't calm you down — you must use physical, somatic signals to tell your brain that you are safe in the present moment.

Technique 1 — The Physiological Sigh

Purpose: Rapidly lowers heart rate and offloads carbon dioxide.

1. Take two quick inhalations through your nose (one deep inhale followed immediately by a short 'top-off' inhale).
2. Exhale slowly and completely through your mouth.
3. Repeat 3 to 5 times.

Technique 2 — 5-4-3-2-1 Sensory Orientation

Purpose: Pulls focus out of mental loops and back to physical surroundings.

- 5 things you can see around you
- 4 things you can physically feel (e.g. feet on floor)
- 3 things you can hear
- 2 things you can smell
- 1 thing you can taste

Technique 3 — Temperature Shift (Mammalian Dive Reflex)

Purpose: Interrupts acute panic loops by stimulating the vagus nerve.

1. Splash cold water on your face, or hold an ice cube in your hand for 30 seconds.
2. Focus entirely on the sensory sensation of the cold temperature.
3. Notice how your heart rate naturally begins to slow down.

"Somatic exercises do not solve life's problems; they restore your capacity to face them with clarity and composure."

Building a Daily Grounding Routine

Rather than waiting for high-stress moments, practice these somatic techniques for 2 minutes every morning. Building nervous system familiarity with calm states during low-stress moments makes recovery easier during acute anxiety.

JOURNALING GUIDE

Weekly Self-Check: Triggers & Patterns

Use this guided space to reflect on your nervous system responses over the past week. Write your observations without self-judgment.

1. Observing Triggers: What specific situations or thoughts triggered stress this week?

2. Somatic Awareness: Where in your body did you feel anxiety first?

3. Default State: Did you default to Fight, Flight, Freeze, or Fawn?

4. Compassionate Action: What reassurance or support did your mind/body need in that moment?

5. Looking Ahead: What is one small grounding practice you will commit to next week?

"Self-awareness is not about perfection. It is about returning to yourself with kindness, again and again."

Mail us your answers on Saarzya@gmail.com

*"You don't have to control your thoughts.
You just have to stop letting them control you."*

— DAN MILLMAN

COMING UP NEXT WEEK

ISSUE 02

Navigating Modern Burnout & Digital Fatigue

Saarzya

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